



Sustainability countenance in brand equity: a critical review and future research directions

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Abstract

Brand equity, a strategic marketing asset, can elicit a welcoming, unique relationship that characterizes the bond between products and customers. An essential aspect of brand equity is sustainability, which has emerged as a paramount issue in environmental concerns that firms cannot overlook. Numerous researchers have presented their empirical findings on brand equity, but, with few exceptions, little knowledge has been published on its conceptualization and measurement. Accordingly, this research provides an in-depth analysis that brings associations to scattered brand equity literature, which merely discusses sustainability/greening as an essential aspect. In doing so, we submit that the sustainability dimension in brand equity can be helpful in two respects: (1) firms can use this concept to mitigate consumer cynicism about green attributes and brand functionality; and (2) it bridges the significant flaws in the current conceptualization of brand equity, which can serve as an inspiration for theoretical soundness and its betterment as a measuring tool. We also put forth that the concept of brand equity should include a sustainability paradigm other than marketing assets and stakeholder value.

Keywords Brand Equity · Sustainability · Brand Management · Stakeholder Theory

Introduction

Factories rust away; Packages become obsolete,
Products lose their relevance. But great brands live
forever.

- Backer Spelvogel Bates

Due to increased sustainable consumption, consumer environmentalism and ecological issues in society (Ishaq 2018; Chen and Chang 2008), companies have focused their efforts on offering eco-friendly products and services to meet environmental needs (Lintukangas et al. 2015; Alniacik et al. 2011; Ishaq 2018). Hence, it appears to be a significant asset for a brand to identify itself as an eco-friendly product. Since the development of green marketing concepts about

three decades ago (Bekk et al. 2016), only a few studies have emphasized the processes that lead a green image concept to brand equity (Chen and Chang 2008). Brand equity has been defined as the reputation and power that a brand has that influences an organization's financial performance (Voss and Gammoh 2004; Ishaq et al. 2014). Chen and Chang (2013) argued that a firm's sustainability commitments resulted in a competitive advantage. The researchers were curious to identify why brands attempt to establish eco-friendly products and services. Understanding this viewpoint is important in identifying whether a brand's sustainability image influences green consumer behaviour.

The story of sustainability was discussed prominently in the Brundtland report (World Commission on Environment and Development 1987), Earth Summits at Rio de Janeiro and Johannesburg in 1992 and 2002, respectively, as “meets the needs of the present without compromising the ability of future generations to respond to their needs”. Lubin and Esty (2010) noted sustainability was an “emerging megatrend”. Practitioners and academics have different perspectives related to sustainability (Sheth et al. 2011). The academic stance on sustainability is based on environmental, social, and economic dimensions (Funk 2003). It is a continual approach that encourages an organization to develop

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its capabilities for facilitation in future turmoil (Chabowski et al. 2011). The economic dimension of sustainability is highly ranked among business researchers as it decreases the chances of a firm's early demise and strengthens its financial position (Szekely and Knirsch 2005). The environmental dimension is related to greening prospects (Schubert et al. 2010). The social aspect is associated with corporate social responsibility (Peloza and Shang 2011). From the practitioner's standpoint, business firms are increasingly interested in learning about sustainability and implementing its principles in business operations (Kumar and Christodouloupoulou 2014). Cronin et al. (2011) argued that firms could not practice sustainability without creating a balance among sustainability's three dimensions.

Many renowned organizations have accepted sustainability as a purposeful business goal and established its link to their marketing functions (Royne et al. 2011; Nidumolu et al. 2009). Firms from industries as diverse as Interface, General Electric, Gap, Hewlett-Packard, Cisco, Patagonia, Starbucks, Walmart, Johnson and Johnson, Caterpillar and Nokia have recognized the importance of sustainability and embraced it wholeheartedly (Sheth et al. 2011). However, environmental and social concerns still require significant consideration on a larger scale. Companies can exploit sustainability to create environmental needs and provide solutions (Pickett-Baker and Ozaki 2008) because consumers in the turbulent market can quickly realize the importance of eco-friendly products. Brands such as GM, Toyota, and Honda exploit environmental concerns effectively in the automobile industry (Oliver and Lee 2010) and consumers are even willing to pay high prices (Royne et al. 2011). The members of an international club named Lifestyles of Health and Sustainability developing on less harmful, healthier brands to achieve a better environment for the society. Therefore, researchers have strongly suggested that companies incorporate sustainability practices into their branding strategies to promote green buying behaviour (Chen 2010; Ng et al. 2014).

The concept of branding has made significant progress in giving superior products and services to the consumers (Keller et al. 2011; Aaker and Joachimsthaler 2012). It now provides the means to differentiate an enterprise's offerings and shape consumer attitude (Keller and Lehmann 2006), provide self-expressive, emotional and functional benefits (Aaker 1997) and stimulate strong customer relationships communally and personally (Schau et al. 2009; Schouten et al. 2007). Brand equity, considered the best way to evaluate brands, is defined as "a set of brand assets and liabilities linked to a brand, its name and symbol that adds to or subtracts from the value provided by a product or service to a firm and/or to the its customers" (Aaker Aaker 1991). Likewise, Keller (1993) stated it is "the differential effect of brand knowledge on consumer response to the marketing of the brand". In academic settings, researchers usually

take one of three perspectives to measure brand equity: the financial aspect (Simon and Sullivan 1993), the customer-based perspective (Yoo and Donthu 2001; Keller 1993; Aaker 1991), and a combination of the two, known as the *comprehensive viewpoint* (Motameni and Shahrokhi 1998).

The significance of brand equity is well documented in the marketing literature (Zhang et al. 2015; Ishaq et al. 2014) and includes consumer preferences, consumer confidence towards brand, effectiveness in marketing communication, brand loyalty, positive word-of-mouth communication, performance and satisfaction (Ishaq et al. 2014; Pappu et al. 2005). Since a plethora of studies has indicated that branding has played a vital role in increasing positive word-of-mouth and customer preferences, the logical question is: What would consumer attitude be if an eco-friendly brand were introduced with full functionality? Reynolds and Phillips (2005) argued that "brand equity has become more important as the key to understanding the objectives, the mechanisms, and the net impact of the holistic impact of marketing"; still, however, the literature on brand equity and its measurement is widely varied and inconclusive. The environmental needs have entirely changed consumer buying behaviour because recent market trends require consumers to pay even higher prices (do Paco et al. 2009). Empirical evidence is available to understand the buying pattern for eco-friendly products such as physical goods, furniture, and supermarkets but buying patterns in the services industry have changed as well, especially the hospitality sector (Pickett-Baker and Ozaki 2008). Hence, it is necessary to add a sustainability paradigm in measuring brand equity for a better understanding of purchasing patterns for both product and services.

In this context, it is not surprising that brand equity measurement has become a marketing performance indicator (Baalbaki and Guzmán 2016; Christodoulides et al. 2015; Veloutsou et al. 2013; Ishaq et al. 2014, Rios and Riquelme 2008; Veloutsou et al. 2017). Various consultancy firms (such as Young and Rubicam, Research International, WPP and Interbrand) have developed proprietary methods to measure brand equity for business firms (Veloutsou et al. 2013). Keller and Lehman (2006) also proposed the development of holistic brand equity measurements as a future research direction for brand management. While considering these recommendations, this conceptual paper assesses the available knowledge on brand equity and its measurement methodologies. As Berthon et al. (2001) argued, "perhaps the only thing that has not been reached concerning brand equity is a conclusion". This study develops an integration and differentiation method for conceptual goals, as proposed by Yadav (2014) and MacInnis (2011). This approach can contribute extensively to the development of marketing theory as it highlights how different conceptual paradigms diverge from one another, recognizes antecedents, and proposes contingencies. In doing so, we provide an overview of



taxonomic frameworks, themes, methodological, and theoretical gaps. In addition, we open a new arena of research for understanding sustainable brand equity and posit future research directions towards integrated sustainable brand equity theory.

Brand equity concept

Contemporary marketing practices and theories have acknowledged brand equity as a key strategic asset for business firms. A brand comprises three unique yet interconnected dimensions: financial markets, product, and customer (Keller and Lehmann 2006). The value acquired from these dimensions is recognized as brand equity. Various researchers have offered a wide assortment of definitions of brand equity, with various influential perspectives (e.g., Christodoulides and de Chernatony 2010). With regard to brand equity, Winters (1991) argued that researchers may provide 10 or maybe 11 definitions of brand equity; as this statement remains valid. The concept of brand equity is significant for practitioners as it is related to the effectiveness of marketing programmes, product quality, barriers to competitive entry, greater promotional activity, and customer loyalty (French and Smith 2013; Farquhar 1989; Erdem and Swait 1998).

As a matter of fact, the measurement method of brand equity, its sources, and conceptual and theoretical foundations are still inconclusive (Ishaq et al. 2014) and taken as the “blind men and elephant” syndrome (Ambler 2003). For instance, there is no agreement in the literature as to whether brand equity refers to the value of the brand itself or the value of the brand name (Baalbaki and Guzmán 2016). The various dimensions of brand equity are summarized in Table 1. Moreover, there is no agreement as to which measurement approach is better for evaluating brand equity (Keller 1993; Aaker 1991). However, financial-based (Simon and Sullivan 1993; Farquhar et al. 1991) and customer-based approaches (Pappu et al. 2005; de Chernatony et al. 2004; Ishaq et al. 2014) are dominant in research streams. The financial-based paradigm of brand equity is related to an organization’s performance and success (Saji et al. 2013; Ailawadi et al. 2001), whereas the customer-based paradigm is associated with the interaction of brand and customer (Veloutsou et al. 2013). This study primarily focuses on customer-based brand equity.

The most common definition arising from branding literature describes brand equity as the value added by the brand name to a product that does not hold a brand name (Sriram and Kalwani 2007). Some authors (Sinclair and Keller 2014) have provided a more comprehensive definition, describing it as the brand value obtained from strong brand associations, awareness, perceived quality, and high levels of brand loyalty, as well as assets such as distribution channels,

patents, and trademarks associated with the brands. Aaker (1991) defined brand equity as “a set of brand assets and liabilities linked to a brand, its name, and symbol that add to or subtract from the value provided by a product or service to a firm and/or to that firm’s customers”. Another explanation of brand equity is an annual incremental contribution of the brand when compared with the base product (Baalbaki and Guzmán 2016). Similarly, Ambler et al. (2002) posited it as the company’s asset developed from different marketing efforts to increase sales and drive future cash flows. Sinclair and Keller (2014) declared brand equity as a strategic asset that can sell or buy on a certain price. Brand equity also symbolizes the mind of customers towards the brand’s images, attitudes, experiences, thoughts, and perceptions (Ambler et al. 2002).

In addition, researchers have also argued about the role of brand equity in crisis and uncertainty as it provides goodwill towards the brand and credibility in the market (Rea et al. 2014; Suder and Suder 2013; Hegner et al. 2014). Brand equity includes the consumer’s attitude towards the brand, perceived quality ratings, brand personality traits, brand image, and brand awareness (Buil et al. 2008). However, the central aspect of brand equity is associations about the brand that consumers hold in their memories (Romaniuk and Nenycz-Thiel 2013). Numerous theoretical and conceptual models are available in the branding literature; however, the Aaker (1991) and Keller (1993) models are the most important because of wide acceptance (Ishaq et al. 2014; Pappu et al. 2005; Jung and Sung 2008; Atilgan et al. 2005).

Methodology

To understand brand equity and its evolution, one must first identify the roots of the concept and appreciate the commonalities and differences of measuring brand equity that described in the academic literature. The literature explains different approaches and models to differentiating brand equity concepts. For this purpose, three distinct areas are identified using the content analysis of 2500+ articles indexed in Scopus and the ISI Web of Knowledge. The three areas are: (1) the conceptual approach, which defines the origin of brand equity and its definition; (2) basic concepts that are used to investigate brand equity measurements; and (3) the studies used to demonstrate the determinants and sources of brand equity. Our theoretical framework is consistent with the applications of Yadav (2014) and MacInnis (2011) in theory development, in which they proposed to integrate and differentiate specific conceptual goals.

We searched the ISI Web of Knowledge with the Social Sciences Citation Index database and Scopus from 1990 to 2016. Results from the Arts and Humanities and Sciences Citation Index were eliminated. Although the concept of



Table 1 Summary of available brand equity dimensions in academic literature. *Source:* Authors elaborate this table from the searches on ISI Web of Knowledge and Scopus

Dimension(s)	Author(s)
Perceived value/brand value	Lassar et al. (1995), Martin and Brown (1990), Netemeyer et al. (2004), Rios and Riquelme (2008), Kamakura and Russell (1993)
Reputation	de Chernatony et al. (2004)
Satisfaction	de Chernatony et al. (2004)
Perceived quality	Aaker (1991), Cobb-Walgren et al. (1995), Yoo and Donthu (2001), Pappu et al. (2005) Washburn and Plank (2002), Ishaq et al. (2014), Martin and Brown (1990), Kamakura and Russell (1993), Veloutsou and Christodoulides (2010)
Willingness to pay premium price	Netemeyer et al. (2004)
Social image	Lassar et al. (1995)
Online experience	Christodoulides et al. (2006)
Commitment	Lassar et al. (1995), Martin and Brown (1990),
Brand associations	Aaker (1991), Cobb-Walgren et al. (1995), Yoo and Donthu (2001), Pappu et al. (2005) Washburn and Plank (2002), Ishaq et al. (2014), Rios and Riquelme (2008), Veloutsou and Christodoulides (2010)
Fulfillment	Christodoulides et al. (2006)
Performance	Lassar et al. (1995)
Brand dominance	Kamakura and Russell (1993)
Attachment	Lassar et al. (1995)
Emotional connection	Christodoulides et al. (2006)
Trustworthiness	Lassar et al. (1995), Martin and Brown (1990),
Brand Strength	Srivastava and Shocker (1991)
Responsive service nature	Christodoulides et al. (2006)
Brand awareness	Aaker (1991), Cobb-Walgren et al. (1995), Yoo and Donthu (2001), Pappu et al. (2005) Washburn and Plank (2002), Ishaq et al. (2014), Rios and Riquelme (2008), Veloutsou and Christodoulides (2010)
Distinctiveness	Netemeyer et al. (2004)
Brand name symbolic utility	Vazquez et al. (2002); Kocak et al. (2007)
Brand image	Martin and Brown (1990), Tolba and Hassan (2009)
Attribute based brand equity and non-attribute-based brand equity	Park and Srinivasan (1994)
Brand loyalty	Aaker (1991), Cobb-Walgren et al. (1995), Yoo and Donthu (2001), Pappu et al. (2005) Washburn and Plank (2002), Ishaq et al. (2014), Rios and Riquelme (2008)
Intangible value	Kamakura and Russell (1993)
Brand name functional utility	Vazquez et al. (2002); Kocak et al. (2007)

brand equity goes back on the 1970s with a complex study of Srinivasan (1979), but we selected 1990 to be a suitable year because this concept started its progression. We used the *topic* field of the ISI search engine to search multiple keywords, using a complete list of possibilities that included “brand equity”, “green brand equity”, “sustainable brand equity,” and “sustainability” with “brand equity”. The search returned highly significant conceptual and empirical references ($n = 2527$; ISI Web of Knowledge = 928, Scopus = 1599) that explicitly addressed the evolution, conceptualization, and measurements of brand equity and its empirical evidence in various cultures.

In the first step following the search, the duplicate articles ($n = 641$) in both databases were deleted. In the next step, empirical and conceptual/review papers on brand equity were separated and analysed for novel theoretical

contribution according to their applications and themes. The third step was a contextual analysis to eliminate articles that had no novel theoretical contribution or that were an extension of available models. Additionally, the empirical and conceptual papers were also excluded if they had no relationship with sustainability or brand equity. Of the 1886 articles, 21 articles were linked to sustainability/eco-friendliness and brand management, whereas only six articles were found that discussed measurement of sustainable/green brand equity as a single variable without theory formulation. Of those six articles, five used the same conceptual paradigm proposed by Chen (2010) to measure green brand equity using a single dimension. The purpose of this research was to identify the progress of brand equity scale development with sustainability aspects hence the prime focus on theory development and empirical research papers. After eliminating general papers,

literature reviews, and empirical papers with no advancement in brand equity scale, we ended up with 57 articles.

Table 2 shows various taxonomies, approaches, and models for measuring and conceptualizing brand equity. The conclusions are summaries of existing brand equity, green-ing, sustainability, and green brand equity literature that show dilemmas and serious questions regarding brand equity management and its creation. There are numerous research studies and approaches to conceptualizing and measuring brand equity in marketing literature; those presented in Table 2 are considered to be the basic conceptual, methodological, and theoretical foundations. Some consultancy firms also offer different scales to measure brand equity. Since the underlying purpose of this study is to provide an academic overview of brand equity and aspects of sustainability, the brand equity scales that could potentially be applied are described in Table 3.

Figure 1 stems from concepts and taxonomies discussed herein. Its purpose is to illustrate the key brand equity concepts from the organizational and consumer standpoints while simultaneously addressing the marketing and finance domains. The upper right quadrant illustrates the consumer/marketing dimensions that have emerged primarily from marketing disciplines to explain the theoretical and empirical foundations of brand equity with a focus on consumer perceptions. The lower left quadrant illustrates the financial/organizational perspective, which concentrates mainly on company actions to elucidate determinants of brand equity. Iglesias et al. (2013) argued that academics should focus more on the systematic view of brand equity development through business techniques and theoretical approaches.

Measurement of brand equity

The brand equity concept was first defined qualitatively by Aaker (1991) and Keller (1993); its empirical measurement was proposed at later stages, i.e., Aaker (1996). Many researchers have also taken the initiative to operationalize this intangible asset with complex statistical procedures and methodologies (Pappu et al. 2005; Yoo and Donthu 2001), although it can be difficult to gain insight from the results. The literature offered two different mechanisms to measure/operationalize brand equity: (1) the indirect approach—measuring brand equity with its demonstrable dimensions, and (2) the direct approach—measuring brand equity directly through utilities or consumer preferences. They observed that the direct measurement method of brand equity lacks theoretical grounds, whereas indirect approaches have methodological and conceptual soundness. Apart from academic measurement of brand equity, various market research firms have also developed instruments that are occasionally referenced in academic literature (see, for

example, Mizik and Jacobson 2008). The summary of brand equity measurement is shown in Table 2.

Using direct measurement approaches, Jourdan (2002), Park and Srinivasan (1994) and Srinivasan (1979) used the multi-attribute model to measure brand equity with a common departure point. Srinivasan (1979) used multi-attribute conjoint analysis to measure brand equity with an observed preference on actual choice compared with consumer preferences. The difference between preferences measured through the multi-attribute approach and overall preference is quantified on a monetary scale. However, this direct measurement approach failed to shed light on brand value sources. About fifteen years later, Park and Srinivasan (1994) developed a survey-based method to measure brand equity in the product category. They defined it as “the difference between an individual consumer’s overall brand preference and the consumer’s multi-attributed preference based on objectively measured attribute levels” (p. 273) and argued that objective preferences could be measured through surveys, blind tests, and laboratory tests. They further categorized the brand equity into two parts: an attribute associated with consumers’ evaluation of physical characteristics of the brand and the non-attribute linked with the symbolic association of the brand. This study provides key insights to resolving perceptual distortions of brand equity; however, the study did not return significant findings for the non-attribute component of brand equity.

Jourdan (2002) worked on Park and Srinivasan’s (1994) model of brand equity with the aim of improving its validity and reliability. He argued that an error term was missing in the calculation of utilities; he found two reasons for this. First, he thought there was a systematic error when they used a multi-attribute model to measure the brand’s objective evaluations. Second, a customer may have a favourable assessment of product attributes but buy a different brand for unknown reasons; Jourdan referred to this as random error. Hence, he performed a repeat experimental design and showed that an error term in Park and Srinivasan’s model could not be neglected. After considering the error term, the validity and reliability of the previous brand equity model increased significantly. Despite having an advantage over its predecessor, Jourdan’s (2002) brand equity model is much more difficult to understand because of its complex experimental design.

Leuthesser et al. (1995) proposed their model of brand equity and argued that consumers always have biased decisions because of a predisposition towards familiar brands. They called this the *halo effect*. Two statistical procedures, called *double centring* and *partialling out*, were proposed; however, these methods could not provide a source of brand equity. Furthermore, this research did not offer any advancement in previous brand equity models and was heavily based on statistical analyses, which made it difficult to grasp.



Table 2 Measuring instruments of brand equity

Year	Author	Objective of the paper	Base conceptualization/research method	Dimensions
1979	Srinivasan	To measure CBBE, the author used multi-attribute model	No theory available previously	Measured brand equity as single dimension
1991	Aaker	Understanding CBBE	No theory available previously/Conceptual Basis	Brand awareness, quality, brand association, and loyalty
1991	Kamakura and Russell	Take brand intangible value and perceived quality	No theory available previously	Brand intangible value and perceived quality
1991	Srivastava and Shocker	Measuring consumer and financial-based brand equity	No theory available previously	Brand strength and brand value
1993	Swait et al.	Equalization Price was used to measure brand equity	No theory available previously	Measured brand equity as single dimension
1993	Simon and Sullivan	Examining financial-based brand equity	No theory available previously	Financial value to the brands
1993	Park and Srinivasan	Individual-level measurement of brand equity	No theory available previously	Non-attribute and attribute-based brand equity
1993	Keller	Understanding CBBE	No theory available previously	Brand knowledge: brand image and brand awareness
1995	Leuthesser et al.	The halo effects measure of brand equity	Thorndike (1920) and Keller (1993)	Measured brand equity as single dimension
1995	Lassar et al.	Measure CBBE	Keller (1993)	Attachment, worthiness, trust, value, social image, and performance
1995	Boone et al.	Examining sports brand equity	No theory available previously	Team revenues, operating expenses, attendance capacity, and financial value
1999	Gladden and Milne	Examining sports brand equity	Boone et al. (1995)	Stadium capacity, ticket price, and franchise value
2000	Berry	Understanding service brand equity	Aaker (1991), Keller (1993)	Brand meaning and brand awareness
2001	Krishnan and Hartline	Testing psychometric properties of CBBE	Aaker (1991), Keller (1993)	Familiarity with brand name, trustworthiness, credibility, quality, and willingness to pay premium price
2001	Yoo and Donthu	Multidimensional scale of brand equity	Aaker (1991, 1996), Keller (1993)	Brand awareness, perceived quality, and brand loyalty
2001	Mackay	Measuring financial brand equity	Aaker (1991), Simon and Sullivan (Simon and Sullivan 1993)	Market share compared with CBBE dimensions of Aaker model
2001	Gladden et al.	Conceptualizing CBBE	Aaker (1991)	Brand awareness, perceived quality, brand association, and brand loyalty
2001	Faircloth et al.	Measuring CBBE	Aaker (1991)	Willingness to pay premium price
2001	Belen del Rio	Investigating CBBE in sports industry	Aaker (1991)	Four brand association dimensions: guarantee, personal identification, social identification, and status
2002	Jourdan	Improvement and amendment in Park and Srinivasan Scale while using experimental design	(Park and Srinivasan 1994)	Non-attribute and attribute-based brand equity
2002	Vazquez et al.	Develop and validate the instrument for measuring CBBE	Kamakura and Russell (1993), Cobb-Walgren et al. (1995)	Brand name utility and product utility
2002	Gladden and Funk	Testing one dimension of brand equity	Aaker (1991)	16 dimensions of brand associations
2002	Washburn and Plank	Modification in Yoo and Donthu (1997) instrument	Aaker (1991, 1996) and Keller (1993)	Brand awareness, perceived quality, and brand loyalty
2003	Robinson and Miller	CBBE in sports industry	Gladden et al. (1998)	Conceptual study



Table 2 (continued)

Year	Author	Objective of the paper	Base conceptualization/research method	Dimensions
2003	Kim et al.	Investigating CBBE	Aaker (1991), Keller (1993)	Brand loyalty, perceived quality, brand awareness, and brand image
2003	Ailwadi et al.	Develop and validate “revenue premium” as consequence of brand equity	Keller (2003)	Revenue premium between brand and private label
2004	Hsieh	Measuring brand equity for automobile industry in 20 countries	Data owned by MORPACE Keller (2003)	Market size, brand attachment, and brand recognition
2004	De Chematony et al.	Measure brand performance for financial sector	Interviews	Reputation, satisfaction, and brand loyalty
2004	Netemeyer et al.	Develop different facets of brand equity scale	Aaker (1991, 1996) and Keller (1993)	Willingness to pay premium price, uniqueness, perceived value, and perceived quality
2005	Bauer, Sauer, and Exler	Examining CBBE	(Park and Srinivasan 1994) and Aaker (1991)	Brand associations related to product and non-product benefits
2005	Bauer, Sauer, and Schmitt	Financial- and consumer-based brand equity	Keller (1993)	Brand awareness, brand image
2005	Bamert and Wehrli	Service based brand equity	Aaker (1991)	Brand loyalty, perceived quality, brand association, and brand awareness
2005	Pappu et al.	Improved version of customer-based brand equity scale	Aaker (1991, 1996) and Keller (1993)	Brand loyalty, perceived quality, brand association, brand personality, and brand awareness
2006	Ross	Proposed CBBE	Aaker (1991)	Brand association and brand awareness
2006	Ross, James, and Vargas	Testing brand association among sports consumer	Aaker (1991)	Qualitative study to test 13 dimensions of brand association
2006	Christodoulides et al.	Conceptualize and measure brand equity for online brands	Qualitative research	Fulfillment, trust, responsive service nature, online experience, and emotional connection
2007	Kaynak et al.	Proposing brand association	Gladden and Funk (2002)	Measuring brand equity theory brand association dimension
2007	Low and Lamb	Testing brand equity’s psychometric properties	Aaker (1991)	Perceived quality, brand image, brand attitude
2007	Boyle and Magnusson	CBBE in sports industry	Aaker (1991), Keller (1993)	Value, success, and quality
2007	Kocak et al.	Replicate Vazquez et al. (2002) study to measure CBBE in cross-cultural analysis. After cross-culture analysis, items were reduced to 16 from 22.	Vazquez et al. (2002)	Brand name utility and product utility
2008	Guizani et al.	Scale development of CBBE in France	Aaker (1991, 1996) and Keller (1993)	Social value, brand knowledge, perceived brand quality, and brand loyalty
2008	Shanker et al.	Test brand equity model	Proposed own theory	Relative brand importance and offering value
2008	Lehmann et al.	Suggested a set of brand measures that can be used to gauge performance of brand	Keller and Lehman (2006)	Preference, interpersonal relations, comparative advantage, comprehension, and attachment
2008	Rajasekar and Nalina	New instrument for CBBE in India	Brucks and Zeithaml (1991) and Aaker (1996)	Attachment, worthiness, trust, value, social image, and performance
2008	Ross, et al.	Evaluating brand equity’s one dimension	Aaker (1991)	Internalization and identification
2008	Buil et al.	Inclusion of personality dimension in brand equity scale designed by Aaker (1991)	Aaker (1991)	Brand association, brand personality, brand loyalty, brand awareness and quality



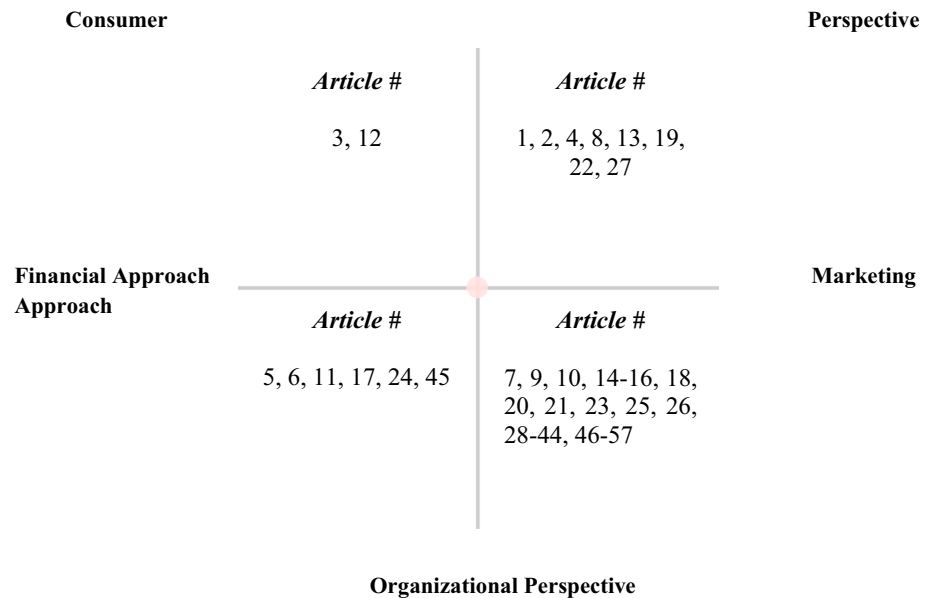
Table 2 (continued)

Year	Author	Objective of the paper	Base conceptualization/research method	Dimensions
2008	Zeugner-Roth et al.	Brand equity scale for country	Aaker (1991), Keller (1993) and Yoo and Donthu (2001)	Country brand awareness/association, perceived country brand quality, and country brand loyalty
2008	Jung and Sung	Brand equity measurement for Levi's, Polo and Gap	Aaker (1991), Keller (1993), Yoo and Donthu (2001)	Overall brand equity, and multidimensional brand equity as proposed by Yoo and Donthu
2008	Lehmann et al.	Measuring brand performance and brand equity with 27 dimensions	Aaker (1991, 1996), Keller (1993), Keller and Lehmann (2006)	Brand loyalty, perceived quality, value, performance, awareness, and image
2008	Lehmann et al. Study 2	Measured brand equity in soft drinks, fast food, and toothpastes	Aaker (1991, 1996), Keller (1993), Keller and Lehmann (2006)	Brand loyalty, perceived quality, value, performance, awareness, and image
2009	Davis et al.	Measure brand equity in logistics industry	Keller (1993)	Overall brand quality, brand image, and brand awareness
2009	Boo et al.	Designed brand quality scale for destination (Atlantic City and Las Vegas)	Aaker (Aaker 1991, 1996), Keller (1993)	Destination brand loyalty, destination brand value, destination brand quality, destination brand image, and destination brand awareness
2009	Atilgan et al.	Inclusion of brand trust as new dimension in brand equity model instead of brand awareness	Aaker (Aaker 1991, 1996), Keller (1993)	Brand trust, brand association, brand loyalty, and perceived quality
2010	Broyles et al.	Measuring functional aspect of quality and performance	Keller (1993)	Brand imagery, and brand resonance
2010	Chen	Measuring green brand equity first time	Aaker (1991) and Keller (1993)	Single dimensional construct
2013	Veloutsou et al.	Identification of brand equity components	Aaker (Aaker 1991, 1996), Keller (1993)	Four major dimensions were identified: consumer behaviour towards brand, affective response towards brand, brand evaluation, and brand characteristics understanding
2015	Christodoulides et al.	Measuring brand equity in cross-cultural settings	Aaker (1991)	Brand loyalty, brand association, perceived quality, and brand awareness

Base conceptualization term in table is explaining the previously underlying theoretical background (if available), and authors elaborate this table from the searches on ISI Web of Knowledge and Scopus

Table 3 Applied brand equity scales

Consultancy name	Scale description
Research International Equity Engine	Functional performance, affinity, and the interaction between brand's price and equity
WPP Brand Dynamics	Bonding, advantage, performance, relevance, and presence
Y&R Brand Asset Valuator	Differentiation, relevance, esteem, and knowledge
Interbrand Brand Strength	Protection, diversification, brand support, trend, brand leadership, and market stability

Fig. 1 Positions matrix of brand equity concepts

Kamakura and Russell (1993) used segment-wise logit models and measured actual purchase behaviours of consumers instead of focusing on preferences; the data were taken from scanners. In this particular study, brand equity was measured as “the implied utility or value assigned to a brand by consumers” (p. 10). Kamakura and Russell (1993) proposed brand value as a proxy of brand equity after eliminating the impact of price promotions and short-term advertising. Tangible and intangible components were identified as sources of brand equity; declared intangible brand value and brand value were the two alternative mechanisms for measuring it.

Swait et al. (1993) used the information economics paradigm to measure brand equity with the help of an entire utility linked with the brand instead of a few utility factors. They offered a new brand equity measure, called *equalization price* (EP), which they defined as “the monetary expression of the utility a consumer attributes to a bundle consisting of a brand name, product attributes, and price” (p. 30). The multinomial logit model used available information related to socio-demographics, image, customer purchases, and product usage. One advantage of this model is that it incorporates the individual-level measurement of brand equity as well as various qualitative variables linked

with the symbolic association. However, this model was unable to measure non-homogeneous consumer choices, as it only focused on the same consumer preferences.

Shankar et al. (2008) proposed a model comprising consumer survey and financial data. In this study, brand equity was taken as a multiplicative component of relative brand importance and offered values. The drivers of the brand image were brand fame, brand regard, brand innovation, brand trust, brand associations, brand fit, brand uniqueness, and brand reputation, as measured through a consumer survey. This model was the first in the academic literature that combined consumer and financial data in measuring brand equity for multicategory brands. The only drawback associated with this model was the unavailability of financial measures for rival brands. For measuring the sustainability factor in brand equity, only Chen (2010) offered a new construct with four items that measured green brand equity in electronics and information products. After this study, a few studies were published (Ng et al. 2014; Chang and Chen 2014) along the same lines of Chen’s (2010) framework. Even though this model measured green brand equity at the individual level, the authors did not explain the underlying factor(s)/dimension(s) that

made up green brand equity with no inclusion of purchase preferences.

Indirect approaches, however, adopt a more holistic view in measuring brand equity either with subdimensions or outcome variables, i.e., price premiums. Brand equity has been defined as “the enhancement in the perceived utility and desirability a brand name confers on a product” (Lassar et al. 1995). Lassar et al. collected the data from consumers in two product categories (watches and TV monitors) and proposed five dimensions (commitment, trustworthiness, social image, value, and performance). This brand equity scale comprised 17 items with adequate levels of discriminant validity and internal consistency. This scale helped the manager to monitor brand performance through a paper and pencil instrument. Among its drawbacks, this scale did not include a behavioural component (behavioural loyalty) for brand equity and solely focused on its associations. Besides, a convenience sample of 113 consumers was used to check the validity; this is inadequate for confirmatory factor analysis. Based on previous studies, Vazquez et al. (2002) proposed another holistic definition of brand equity as “overall utility that the consumer associates to the use and consumption of the brand, including associations expressing both functional and symbolic utilities”.

The above studies were performed on utilities acquired before consumer purchases (ex-ante utilities), whereas Vazquez et al.’s (2002) study focused on utilities obtained after purchasing of the brand (ex-post utilities) under an information economics paradigm. Vazquez et al. collected the data from athletic shoe brands and identified four dimensions of brand utility: brand name symbolic utility, product symbolic utility, brand name functional utility, and product functional utility. Confirmatory factor analysis with strong psychometric properties proposed a 22-item scale for brand equity. The results also showed that consumers do not consider brand and product utilities to be identical because the results showed adequate discriminant validity separately. Among the various advantages of this study on predecessors, this method was relatively simple to understand for corporate managers and easy to implement. Among its drawbacks, this scale was difficult to adopt in some industries as it was calibrated only for athletic shoes and focused only on ex-post brand utilities without measuring the significance of ex-ante utilities.

To determine validity and reliability, Kocak et al. (2007) replicated the study of Vazquez et al. (2002), with the same brand equity dimensions, in the Turkish sports shoe industry. Instead of the 22-item scale proposed by Vazquez et al. (2002) which is incompatible with Turkish culture, a 16-item scale with a slight difference was found to be statistically significant. This study revealed that consumers might approach brands differently in different cultures. In another study, Rajh (2002) proposed a 14-item scale across four

dimensions (uniqueness of brand associations, favourability of brand associations, the strength of brand associations, and brand awareness) to measure brand equity while using Keller’s (1993) brand equity framework. This scale had a couple of drawbacks: (1) a 2-item brand awareness scale, which made it a weak instrument (Churchill 1979) and (2) the scale was tested in only one cultural setting (Croatia) on undergraduate students.

Numerous researchers (e.g., de Chernatony et al. 2004) have also tried to provide industry or category-based measures for brand equity. De Chernatony et al. (2004) proposed a three-dimension brand equity construct (reputation, satisfaction, and brand loyalty) in the financial service industry. In another study, Christodoulides et al. (2006) offered brand equity measures in the online industry. They proposed a five-dimension e-tail brand equity scale: fulfillment, trust, responsive service nature, online experience, and emotional connection. Brand equity was also measured in the logistics industry by Davis et al. (2009); this study is considered to be ground-breaking in logistic branding research. Moreover, a five-dimension brand equity scale was developed across different destinations (Atlantic City and Las Vegas): destination brand loyalty, destination brand value, destination brand quality, destination brand image, and destination brand awareness (Boo et al. 2009). Rajasekar and Nalina (2008) developed five facets (attachments, trustworthiness, value, social image, and performance) to measure brand equity for a single destination.

The most important multidimensional scale for measuring brand equity was developed by Yoo and Donthu (2001), in line with Keller’s (1993) and Aaker’s (1991) theories. This scale comprised three dimensions: brand associations/awareness, brand perceived quality, and brand loyalty. To assess the convergent validity of this instrument, a composite scale was developed separately to measure overall brand equity. This study took a sample from multiple cultures in various product categories to make it acceptable for both researchers and brand managers. Nevertheless, this scale also had some limitations. Aaker’s (1991) and Keller’s (1993) theories were used in scale development where the authors provided a clear distinction between brand associations and brand awareness; however, Yoo and Donthu (2001) merged these dimensions into one. For scale development, they collected the data from product categories (colour televisions, athletic shoes, and camera film) and entirely ignored the service industry, which ranks higher for brand equity.

To overcome the most serious limitation of Yoo and Donthu’s (2001) scale, Pappu et al. (2005) differentiated between brand associations and brand awareness. However, they did not complete the scale’s psychometric properties, as they developed brand loyalty with two items but brand awareness with only one item. In both studies, they used student samples to create and validate brand equity scales,



which could not be considered to be key correspondents for effective generalizability as compared to a general consumer sample. Four dimensions (willingness to pay a premium price, uniqueness, value for the cost, and perceived quality) were also offered by Netemeyer et al (2004) to assess brand equity in adult consumers. The four-dimension construct for measuring customer-based brand equity (brand associations, brand loyalty, perceived quality, and brand awareness) was developed in two samples from Spain and the UK, which supports the results in both countries (Buil et al. 2008). In a recent study, Mohan et al (2017) conducted a pair of studies in line with Keller's (2013) call for research on brand functionality. The results showed a significant relationship between brand functionality, brand equity, and brand connection.

Sustainability—missing link

Over the years, public demand has risen significantly for environment-friendly products. Due to rising interest, researchers have studied this phenomenon from multiple standpoints (e.g., Van de Velde et al. 2010). Such studies have proven the close relationship of the environment with buying behaviour (Connell et al. 2012; Ishaq 2018). A plethora of empirical studies (Namkung and Jang 2013; Kucukusta et al. 2013; Saari et al. 2017) and theoretical papers (Kumar and Christodouloupoulou 2014; Gupta and Kumar 2013) link brand management and sustainability, but there is no coherent framework that relates to sustainability as an aspect of the multidimensional brand equity construct. The conceptualizations of brand equity primarily originated from information economics and cognitive psychology. The leading conceptual background of brand equity has been substantiated by cognitive psychology, where researchers focused on memory structure (Keller 1993; Aaker 1991).

The sustainability concept originated in academic literature following the deterioration of the Earth's climate and environment (Fadeeva 2005). The term *sustainability* is defined as "an organizational practice that encourages minimization of the energy used and efficient use of the waste produced so that the adverse effects of the firm's actions on the human race can be reduced" (Eltayeb et al. 2011). Consumers' environmental attitudes are explained as an individual's behaviour, feelings, and beliefs towards eco-friendly concerns (Milfont and Duckitt 2010). Connelly et al. (2011) proposed a list of organizational theories that can be implemented in sustainability research, i.e., signalling theory, social network theory, upper echelons theory, resource-based view, resource dependency theory, population ecology, institutional theory, agency theory, and transaction cost economies. Leonidou and Leonidou (2011) argued that sustainability research has

grown exponentially in management journals, but there is a dearth of material in marketing journals.

Kotler (2011) strongly proposed incorporating the environmental agenda in marketing theory and practices. Chabowski et al. (2011) are considered to be the most influential authors in extensive sustainability-related reviews and research in the marketing stream. They developed a sustainability capability typology that categories classify as legal, ethical, or discretionary (intent-based capability), environmental vs. social (emphasis-based capability), and internal vs. external (resource-based capability). Since the last decade, we have observed numerous moral testimonials on issues of social responsibility, sustainability, and ethics in corporate branding and communication (Kumar and Christodouloupoulou 2014; Sharma et al. 2010; Dao et al. 2011). Since the globalization era began, organizations have been considering sustainability or social responsibility with keen interest and trying to adopt them as the business case or market success (Carroll and Shabana 2010).

In view of environmental concerns that plague the entire planet (for example, resource depletion, air/water pollution, habitat destruction, environmental degradation, and global warming), consumers are actively looking for eco-friendly products in order to make their contribution to the well-being of the world (Jones et al. 2016; Farber et al. 2012; Ishaq 2018). Moreover, consumers are actively making their purchase decisions based on the company's commitment to the environment (Auger et al. 2010). Consequently, the concept of greening or sustainability is both growing and real (Hartmann and Ibáñez 2006) and companies are embracing it in their strategic planning (Kang and Hur 2012; Öberseder et al. 2014). Saari et al (2017) conducted a cross-cultural study to identify the eco-friendly brands in the smartphone industry. They argued that brand experience could help companies to track the success of their sustainable initiatives.

However, there is no coherent theoretical framework in brand management that links sustainability with brand equity. Hence, the only way to link them is the notion of differences and consistency behind corporate brands that have shaped brand management practices. The sustainable programme is an uneven process rather than linear. It comprises numerous strategies that connect the corporate brand with the decision-making process, consumer values, and social causes (Peloza and Shang 2011), thereby establishing strong brand equity for the eco-friendly organization. Organizations can assess the effectiveness of sustainability implementation in branding strategies through differentiation and the ability to satisfy the customer (Bose and Luo 2011). Bridges and Wilhelm (2008) contended that to manage differentiation, organizations should persuade and educate their target market regarding societal marketing steps taken for the betterment of society.



Each firm adopts a unique way to communicate its green initiatives and highlight its involvement in the ecological health of the community; this makes it difficult for consumers to choose a suitable eco-friendly brand (Crittenden et al. 2011). So, this differentiation strategy will help organizations to build strong brand equity, which will provide consumers a product with better performance as compared to competitors. Moreover, sustainability aspects in brand equity can create competitive advantage, strong brand positioning, enhance corporate image, provide the power to seize large market share, and access to new target markets.

Sheth et al (2011) claimed that the awareness of sustainability is reached at its peak and a greater showstopper than capital or technology. In this scenario, building sustainable brand equity for any organization is an intimidating assignment. The sustainability role in business operations is taken as a determinant of an organization's capability to deliver efficiently (Dao et al. 2011). Since environmental commitment enables an organization to achieve a green competitive advantage, the companies with low or no focus on ecologically friendly services or products are still trying to portray green images—an integral part of brand equity, as per Aaker's (1991) model. To develop a sustainable brand image, organizations must focus on triple bottom line theory, i.e., financial, social, and environmental (or ecological). Grace and O'Cass (2002) describe the brand as a tool that combines the social environment with the business by establishing associations between customers and business organizations. Brand association—the brand equity facet—contributes to sustainability when the brand participates in green initiatives (Chatterjee 2009). Whenever a company communicates its green initiatives as brand communication, consumers respond positively to it and increase confidence in buying intentions.

Sustainability is taken as a significant predictor of examining brand equity because of active consciousness on the part of consumers in recent years. They are familiar with the brands that have offered healthy, sustainable, environmentally responsible, and eco-safe products, and become more loyal. Sheth et al (2011) claimed that rising numbers of customers worry about the environment and think about going green, as well as reusing and recycling products. This stage is where the sustainability dimension comes into play to measure brand equity of traditional vs. green brands. As established above, research indicates how sustainable practices embraced by an organization to manage its processes become factors of its strength, being positively related to signs of performance and competitiveness (e.g., Jacobs et al. 2010). These firms could reap additional advantages by empowering their consumers to understand the brand-related values and sustainability practices that have paramount influences on their lives. Brands should weigh the social and ecological requirements of stakeholders or consumers and

communicate the methods they have adopted to create a sustainable environment and customer value.

Stakeholder orientation, branding, and sustainability

The normative notion in marketing is to maximize the benefits for all stakeholders, including value chain participants, governments, advocacy groups, and regulators (Chakravorti 2010). This differs from instrumental marketing, where organizations can reap maximum profits by satisfying their needs (Ishaq et al. 2014; Smith et al. 2010). Researchers have claimed that the only way to move from the marketing discipline to the stakeholder perspective is through practicing sustainability marketing (Laczniak and Murphy 2012; Scandellus and Cohen 2016). The sustainability perspective is based on the tripartite view—profit, planet, and people—which received significant acceptance worldwide as a manifestation of the balanced scorecard. In this context, managing differentiation in vibrant market situations requires firms to persuade and educate their consumers about their welfare initiatives for the society (Bridges and Wilhelm 2008). Brands as an intangible asset of an organization may be used as a tool to educate consumers and in designing creative marketing techniques and effective implementation (Day 2011).

The field of marketing has recently expanded such that the stakeholder perspective is relatively new to it (Theodoulidis et al. 2017; Parmar et al. 2010). Marketers are still unclear as to how stakeholder theory will be acknowledged and applied in corporate life. Some examples indicate stakeholder theory is being put into practice, but the nature of its implementation is triggered by external pressure and is more instrumental rather than based on organizational philosophy (Sheth and Sinha 2015). Branding in the sustainability paradigm can influence stakeholder perceptions positively (Brown and Dacin 1997) and customer satisfaction (Luo and Bhattacharya 2009). Chabowski et al. (2011) conducted a literature review on sustainability from 1958 to 2008 and found that environmental sustainability and even economic sustainability have been growing in importance recently, even though most of the population is living below the poverty line. Therefore, firms should adopt sustainability as their branding manifesto in emergent economies through the cultural and holistic approach of considering the environment and local community (Cayla and Arnould 2008). On the other side of the coin, organizations have had poor direction in maintaining conflicting interests and acquiring critical brand differentiation while communicating and leveraging their commitment, involvement, and global influence (Kaynak and Zhou 2010; Chakravorti 2010).



Despite the research gap in the abovementioned areas and the insufficiency of institutional frameworks, scientific talent, infrastructure, and regulatory enforcement, some renowned brands have been implementing sustainability in their branding strategies for multiple stakeholders. For instance, some brands are working on minimizing pollution, waste, and resource utilization to retain consumers. Others are working on greening the supply chain (e.g., recycling units, waste disposal, retail stores, distribution systems, storage facilities and raw material extraction units), repairing/recycling/remanufacturing processes, and reducing over-production (Sharma et al. 2010). Caterpillar is investing in poverty reduction, reduced emissions, water conservation, energy conversation, and employee safety, and BHP Billiton devotes 1% of its profit to the development of the local community. Many other firms are also communicating their sustainable goals to the community, showing their commitment as moral citizens, decentralizing distribution and production, and producing affordable, eco-friendly brands (Hoejmose et al. 2012). Therefore, all firms should maintain sustainability-based corporate branding strategies that are both pervasive and programmatic. Furthermore, they should invest in competitive conditions, socio-cultural, technological, and economical perspectives (Crane et al. 2014), especially where they impinge upon economic, environmental, and social issues (Czinkota et al. 2014).

To address unsustainable practices in branding/marketing, firms should adhere to corporate social responsibility strategies or corporate sustainability as a wider responsibility (Kumar and Christodouloupoulou 2014; Lindgreen et al. 2012). The ideal collaboration among all stakeholders should form a value co-creation to ensure the societal impact and strengthen community relationships. Given the mounting comprehension of stakeholders in the marketing domain, Du et al. (2010) urged that marketers should investigate stakeholder orientation of business firms in terms of environmental, social, and economic aspects. This consideration is ethical but also a business necessity that can boost brand reputation, market value, return on investment, firm performance, and brand value (Kumar and Christodouloupoulou 2014). Additionally, some researchers (Sierra et al. 2017; Balmer 2001) have claimed that the current socioeconomic environment becomes relevant for the brands to incorporate ethical and societal commitments at the corporate level, as they enhance the brand's reputation.

Firms are trying to increase their brand equity with the help of economic sustainability and stakeholder orientation through accessing economically disadvantaged markets to increase market growth and local community development. For instance, the Shell Foundation provides inexpensive energy products, Amanco/Ashoka offers loans for farmers, Masisa enhances carpenters' living, Barrick finances education to increase employment prospects, and Dow provides

funding and affordable housing for community development. Some brands also reap economic benefits from practicing sustainability; one example is Shree Cement's sale of low-cost electricity and reduced electric consumption. Moreover, business-to-business firms can also build positive economic influence by making their brands affordable, upgradable, re-saleable, repairable, durable, multi-user, and shareable (Sheth et al. 2011).

By engaging in social responsibility, many firms are codeveloping and coevolving national, regional, or local communities. For example, Shell Foundation has numerous partnerships with global entrepreneurs for eco-friendly, low-cost, and innovative solutions for solar energy. This initiative has entirely changed the communities but also linked the brand with values such as openness towards substitute energy sources, future-oriented entrepreneurship, and innovativeness, despite the fact that Shell's core business is not related to renewable energy development. In the process of partnering and networking, these businesses typically advance business expertise, while social entrepreneurs provide deep insights, strong social networks, and low-cost brands for communities. BHP Billiton's funding for sports centres and theatres and Masisa's work for social housing have created a vivacious community that will only support such firms with social business objectives; this, in return, enhances brand reputation and brand equity.

Sheth and Sinha (2015) argued that the economic and social status of the community drives consumption; however, this consumption damages the environment. For this reason, the way firms offer balance and promote measures to save the environment is notable. Some examples include BHP Billiton starting an internal environment management audits/programme, Shree Cements focusing on building green power plants and dramatically lowering emissions, Barrick's promoting awareness initiatives for land degradation and water pollution, Masisa's forest cover plantation, biomass gasification by the Shell Foundation, Dow's waste management systems, and Amanco/Ashoka's irrigation techniques. These are considered some of the best examples of firms that endeavoured to better use limited natural resources.

We believe that businesses having stakeholder orientations can address environmental, economic, and social challenges decently after embracing sustainability for the community they serve with eco-friendly products, advertising, and packaging. This step would enhance corporate reputations because this perspective is not just instrumental where people managed through marketing; instead, it is normative as well, which leads to ethical decision-making. Lai et al (2010) empirically verified the positive links between corporate reputation and industrial brand equity and organizational performance to the business industry. In current brand management research, branding literature is



significantly shifting towards a perspective of stakeholder co-creation, where brands are perceived as a social process (Hult et al. 2011); however, this point of view is somehow unnoticed. Balmer and Grey (2003) asserted that branding is considered to be an internally driven process where literature always take the managerial perspective while supposing that customers are only passive receivers; they then react in accordance with the organization's will. This assessment suggests that stakeholders are considered to be branding targets instead of co-creators or partners in branding (Gregory 2007), hence ignoring the consumers' perceptions of brand equity.

Recently, the stakeholder viewpoint (Zhang et al. 2016) of brand management has been introduced. This view acknowledges the active participation and social interactions among multiple stakeholders in branding co-creation and brand discourse. With regard to the sustainability paradigm, Sisodia et al. (2003) conducted empirical research that used a multiple bottom line approach on 30 firms. They found that the stakeholder versus shareholder dichotomy is false. Moreover, the authors claimed that the organizations having a profit orientation were not profitable most of the time; highly profitable organizations, on the other hand, were those who had no primarily profitable purpose. This type of orientation was coined by Philip Kotler four decades ago (Kotler and Armstrong 2010). The organizations that failed in the interconnection of ecosystems and stakeholders (Korschun et al. 2014) suffered from *new marketing myopia* (Smith et al. 2010). We believe that shifting brand equity's literature from a market orientation and customer focus to a stakeholder orientation can only be achieved with the integration of sustainability.

Conclusion, recommendations, and future research directions

Brooks and Rich (2016) argued that the sustainability paradigm in business operations is not mandatory. However, the intense pressure to incorporate sustainability comes from four sources: (1) institutional forces in the form of expectations and norms; (2) societal stakeholders; (3) legislation, e.g., the United Nations Global Compact; and (4) corporate stakeholders as suppliers, customers, employees, and investors (WBCSD 2000). Moreover, Stohl et al. (2007) argued that researchers and practitioners should reconsider sustainability as a global framework. They further argued that sustainability "is responsive to the multiple cultures, value sets, and communicative practices of different nations while recognizing that (inter) organizational contexts are no longer bounded by the nation-state". In line with this argument, Bondy et al. (2012) also drew the same conclusion and contended that there is a

move towards standardization and institutionalization. Businesses can communicate, demonstrate, and address sustainability through external linkages and internal voluntary initiatives (Aggerholm et al. 2011). The academic literature on sustainability is primarily focused on its policies (Chen 2010), evaluation of green marketing strategies (Cronin et al. 2011), and diverse theoretical approaches.

Some researchers have also investigated organizations' motives in adopting sustainability practices through green initiatives (Sharma et al. 2010; Cronin et al. 2011), as it enhances product value and engenders opportunities to enter into new markets (Chen 2010), the prospect to develop reputation and favourable corporate image (Sheth et al. 2011), links with the disposal of waste material (Tzschentke et al. 2008), and pressure from government, stakeholders, or competitors (Delmas and Toffel 2008). In some situations, consumers are also exposed when they must choose from a wide range of products and brands that have different eco-friendly features. For instance, a brand might offer a financial donation for an environmental reason (cause-related marketing), several certifications related to the environment (green labelling), green packaging, or environmentally preferable products (Sony et al. 2015).

Chen (2010) pointed out reasons for organizations to adopt environmental sustainability practices that are: enhancing product value, seeking opportunities in new markets, improving corporate image, and obtaining a competitive advantage. Patagonia is considered to be a key brand that introduced sustainability practices a long time ago and is committed to making its products landfill-free and recyclable. Adidas, H&M, IKEA, Marks & Spencer, and Levi Strauss reduced the amount of water usage and pesticides after supporting Better Cotton Initiatives (BCI) (Confino 2011). Levi Strauss introduced less water consumption in finishing off its product, and H&M exploits its Conscious Collection brand line which is made up of recycled polyester, Tencel, organic linen, and cotton. Unilever also initiated its Sustainability Living Plan in 2011 to halve its eco-friendly footprint by 2020. Following implementation, Unilever reported higher business growth within one year. General Electric's Ecomagination Research and Development Program, a successful example of eco-friendly branding, was introduced with an extensive marketing budget for mobile phone apps, online videos, print advertising, and TV commercials. GE reserved a \$1 billion annual budget for this campaign and statistics have shown that GE reaped a substantial \$21 billion return in a single year. Timberland, Walmart, IBM, and Starbucks are among the other companies that have successfully transformed themselves as sustainable brands. Hence, this study argues that implementing eco-friendly practices could raise a firm's sustainable brand equities.



The brand equity sustainability approach is based on offering a differentiated product with the eco-friendly product, name, packaging, and symbols that offer green value and functional and emotional benefits to consumers. Since a holistic framework requires the implementation of green initiatives to become an environmentally friendly organization (Szekely and Knirsch 2005), and acting according to rational needs to justify its businesses (Crittenden et al. 2011), this can become a strategic asset that can help an organization to buy or sell at a certain price for a higher profit margin. Rindfleisch et al. (2010) claimed that consumers are becoming more knowledgeable about how they perceive sustainability in brand and marketing strategies. Sustainable brand equity not only directs consumers towards green branding, but it can also deliver brand credibility during uncertainty and crisis. Hendrickx and Nicolaij (2004) contended it is highly unlikely that a customer will prefer traditional branding attributes like credibility, quality, and price over a sustainable branding strategy. In the meantime, consumer needs have shifted significantly towards environmental responsibility; the implementation of such initiatives would provide a crucial competitive advantage (Namkung and Jang 2013), well-heelled and loyal consumers and increased price premiums (Grimmer and Bingham 2013).

The purpose of this paper is to identify the specific conceptual goals related to brand equity and sustainability as a key dimension, segregate the conflicting paradigms, and synthesize the contemporary approaches. The findings identify gaps in the conceptualization of brand equity and practice existing in the marketing/company, consumer/financial, and consumer/company value creation domains. Our taxonomic framework (see Fig. 1 and Table 2) indicates that several researchers pursued brand equity's metric approach (Ambler 2008; Yoo et al. 2000; Srinivasan et al. 2005; Ailawadi et al. 2003; Kamakura and Russell 1993; Simon and Sullivan 1993) and conceptualization approach (Keller and Lehmann 2006; Ambler 2008; Yoo et al. 2000; Keller 1993; Aaker 1991; Pappu et al. 2005; Chen 2010) to analyse the determinants of brand equity. After presenting different typologies of brand equity existing in the literature, we concluded there is a need for future studies that elicit a better explanation of brand equity formation and inclusion of new dimension(s).

There is a dearth of branding or marketing theories that integrate sustainability as key aspects of the brand equity model posited by various researchers, especially Aaker's (Aaker 1991) and Keller's (1993) frameworks. We address this gap by coining a new dimension in the brand equity model, i.e., sustainability. A strong brand always enjoys robust brand equity because it delivers meaningful and differentiated value to the consumers (Szekely and Knirsch 2005) and those brands that provide superior customer values are sustainable (Srivastava et al. 1998); we consider this

to be sustainable brand equity. As per our understanding, the brand plays a significant role. We, therefore, suppose two business-centric situations: (1) a sustainable brand equity aspect has the ability to influence organizations' operational, management, and marketing opportunities to cater positively to consumers' eco-friendly demands; and (2) a sustainable brand equity aspect can create sustainable competitive advantage with the help of sustainability's three dimensions, i.e., environmental protection, social well-being, and economic development. We believe that businesses with a stakeholder orientation are served better by the implementation of sustainability brand management strategies to address environmental, economic, and social challenges of the community in which they operate.

We recommend future research directions that originate from what we found in the existing literature of brand equity that can be coupled by recourse to the future research directions, integrating sustainability in a brand equity model, and other formats previously proposed. There is a need for simultaneous and systemic integration among interdisciplinary topics. We propose avenues for future research that should give rise to sustainable brand equity in the context of stakeholder theory (company and consumer value perspective) and the societal marketing concepts proposed by Kotler in 1970s. The academic literature recommends further research in the stakeholder and societal marketing domains. This notion is in line with contemporary approaches (Davicik et al. 2015; Hult et al. 2011; Iglesias et al. 2013). We assert that the stakeholder and societal marketing concept is a significant pillar of brand equity that postulates brand equity as the dynamic and social practice of eco-friendly brand creation among stakeholders instead of the limited and narrow perspective at the company or consumer end. Those organizations that are unable to create linked stakeholder and ecosystem perspectives in their business operations are classified as having new marketing myopia (Smith et al. 2010).

The importance of brand equity theory has been of significant interest in academic research for the last two decades; however, there is no agreement on its measurement as a single or multidimensional construct. To study brand equity as a multidimensional construct, we call for the development of a comprehensive scale approach with the integration of sustainability. There are eight contributions in marketing literature for theory building (Yadav 2014; MacInnis 2011). This process indicates the expansion of knowledge develops and forms new contingencies. While taking this approach into consideration, this conceptual study addresses the integration and differentiation perspectives. To accumulate and integrate the brand equity's literature for explicit conceptual objectives, based on Yadav's (2014) and MacInnis's (2011) theoretical framework, we followed three steps: (1) measurement approaches of brand



equity; (2) determinants of brand equity; and (3) sources of brand equity. The purpose behind explicit conceptual objectives is to distinguish different approaches and combine sustainability aspects in the concept of brand equity as a contemporary approach. This conceptual paper tries to identify the gap not only in the theoretical model of brand equity but also in the marketing/company, consumer/financial, and consumer/company value creation domains in practice. Our research on the brand equity framework indicates that several authors provided their brand equity framework (e.g., Keller and Lehmann 2006; Srinivasan et al. 2005; Ailawadi et al. 2003; Yoo et al. 2000), and none of them have tried to explore sustainability. After analysing the giving taxonomies, we concluded that the brand equity concept required a more theoretical foundation to address the gap, specifically in the context of sustainability. Eventually, what is pursued is an exploration of the Holy Grail of brand management, a general and unified theory of brand equity. The theory must encompass not only marketing performance notions, net cash flows, or short-term profits, but also take into account future changes in stakeholder orientation and value propositions that will help an organization to sustain itself in a challenging environment.

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